

Progressivism

Introduction

Progressive education is a philosophy of thinking modified from Charles Darwin's theory of evolution, with its emphasis on change and adaptation, and has its roots anchored in pragmatism (Gutek 1988). Progressivism is an educational philosophy focused on equipping students with the skills and knowledge necessary not only to survive but also to succeed in a contemporary, competitive society. Progressivism is a school of thought that advocates that truth is determined by function. John Dewey was considered one of the leading proponents of the revival and evolution of American education (Gutek 1988). He was the leading educational purveyor of progressive education.

Educational Philosophy

Progressivism is a philosophy that is adaptable to an ever-changing world. It is a philosophy that promotes education to help students develop the problem-solving skills needed to function successfully in a competitive society. Progressivism focuses on educating students in a manner that prepares them to become productive adults who function adeptly in an ever-changing world. The philosophy is based on the belief that people learn best from what they consider most relevant to their lives, experiences, interests, projects, and abilities.

Curriculum

The curriculum has a strong emphasis on problem solving, analysis, and rational thinking. These skills are important today. Without problem-solving abilities, an individual is lost and alone in the puzzling maze of society that characterizes today's world. A progressive curriculum is centered on activities and instruction that challenge students' problem-solving and analytical abilities, strengthening these skills. An individual using the problem-solving approach and the experimental focus of the scientific method to govern their own life is the building block of how reasonable and ethical organizations operate. Schools should be student-centered, with the curriculum and instruction tailored to facilitate individual development. Since progressivism is influenced by contemporary society, it is only appropriate that the progressivism curriculum is geared toward providing students with real-world skill instruction that involves higher levels of investigation and analysis.

Methodology of Instruction

The teaching methods used in a progressivist classroom support problem-based learning and play an important role in students' learning. The classroom environment would invite participation, involvement, and democratic learning. In a progressivist classroom, the teacher plans lessons to arouse curiosity and push the student to a higher level of knowledge. The lesson plans would be organized creatively and would involve lectures, discussions, research, experiments, and critical thinking. Not every student learns the same way, and lessons need to be engaging and tailored to all types of learners. Students will engage in hands-on activities to demonstrate that they have control over their learning. They are encouraged to learn by doing and to interact with one another. Working in a small group is an encouraged method to discuss, share, and compromise. The problems students solve in the classroom are designed to be similar to those students will encounter in the real world. The teacher's role in a classroom is to encourage and facilitate the problem-solving process, rather than to provide prescribed solutions. Similarly, the learning environment is collaborative and democratic, giving opportunity for all to speak their minds and receive feedback from peers as well as the teacher. This continuous loop of feedback, potentially positive or negative, serves as the means of assessment for problem-solving-based instruction.

Role of the Teacher and Learner

The role of the teacher is to facilitate learning by posing questions that engage students' minds in practical ways. The student is responsible for his or her own actions and choices. Teachers are responsible for preparing students for the real world, and it is within the classroom setting that they must recreate problems that exist in society and guide students toward solving them. Teachers who follow the philosophy of progressivism encourage both creative and analytic thinking. The questions they pose to their students are often open-ended and may or may not have prescribed answers. Progressivism is centered on an ever-changing society, so today's problems are increasingly intricate and complex, demanding that students use creativity and ingenuity to find the most viable solutions. Teachers act as liaisons between the shelter of childhood and the harshness of the real world, and it is their responsibility to introduce the reality of being a productive member of society to their students, along with the expectations and obstacles that lie before them on their path to success.

Conclusion

Progressivism is a reaction against tradition. I agree with John Dewey's philosophy of progressivism and feel that students should learn through inquiry and by stimulating their own

interests, ideas, and imaginations. The teacher is an administrator, facilitator, inquirer, and resource person, and strives to assist students in discussing the problem-solving issues that arise throughout our decision-making process. As a teacher, I want my students to be aware of the problems in our environment and to develop solutions, whether in the classroom or in the real world. As a teacher, my focus will be on the students, who will come first and foremost. As of right now, my personal philosophy of education is closely aligned with a progressivist approach.

References

- Gutek, G. L. (1988) Philosophical and Ideological Perspectives on Education, Englewood Cliffs, New Jersey: Prentice Hall.
- Knight, G.R. (1982) Issues and Alternatives in Educational Philosophy, Berrien Springs, Michigan: Andrew University Press.